

# BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter **The Daily Ceilidh**  
in association with

## COVID UPDATE

On June 1st, the Western Isles entered tier 0 of the Coronavirus Protection Levels. Although caution is still advised, due to low case numbers on the islands, and high vaccination rates, we are now permitted a wider range of freedoms:

### **You can meet socially in groups:**

Of up to 8 people from 4 households in your home or theirs, and can stay overnight.

Of up to 10 people from 4 households in an indoor public place like a café, pub or restaurant.

Of up to 15 people from 15 households outdoors.

Under 12s do not count towards the total number of people or households when meeting outside, but do count towards the household numbers indoors.

In addition, you do not need to physically distance yourself from family and friends in a private home.

Travel is allowed within the UK, but you must not enter a Level 3 or 4 area unless for a permitted reason. Before you travel you must check the travel rules of the country you wish to visit.

You are asked to test yourself prior to returning to the islands after any travel to the mainland.

Test kits can be ordered for free by calling **119**, or by visiting <https://test-for-coronavirus.service.gov.uk/order-lateral-flow-kits/condition>

## COMMUNITY GETS "PUMPED"

It was a great day on Wednesday 23rd June, when the pump for the Bernera Community Association Petrol Station in Breacleite was installed.



Bernera residents and visitors are able to enjoy the convenience of petrol and diesel, 24 hours a day, at the same price as in Stornoway, thanks to the efforts of the BCA, support from the BCC and BCDT, Highland Fuels, as well as funding from the Crown Estate.

We hope that everyone supports this initiative and buys local.

Welcome to Issue 16 of the Bernera News. The summer is here and finally the cooler north winds have slowed to only occasional, so hopefully we are due some fine weather.

Passing the summer solstice means that the days are shortening, the lambing season is over and children are now on their summer holidays. It has been particularly sad that the Bernera School closed on Friday 26th June and we know that this will be hard for many to see. This is the end of an era, lasting 140 years, of learning on the island which many residents will remember fondly.

It's also been sad to hear of more members of the community that are no longer with us. Our thoughts go out to those of you affected. We ask that family or friends of those recently departed consider sending us something to include in future issues. Dr Hay is remembered in a memoriam on Page 3.

We hope you are growing your sunflowers in earnest and that the finer weather is favouring your efforts. If you have anything that you'd like us to include, or suggestions on what we might be able to do better, please don't hesitate to get in touch.

**Contact us at:** 01851 600 159

**Text/Whatsapp:** 07958 549784

**Email:** [hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk](mailto:hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk)

**Or visit us online at:**

[www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk](http://www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk)

## LANGABHAT MEDICAL PRACTICE

New Surgery opening times from 7 June 2021

|          | MONDAY             | TUESDAY                        | WEDNESDAY                                  | THURSDAY  | FRIDAY       |
|----------|--------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------|--------------|
| LEURBOST | 8am - 6pm          | 8am - 6pm                      | 8am - 6pm                                  | 8am - 6pm | 8am - 6pm    |
| CARLOWAY | 8am - 5pm          | 9.20am - 11am<br>(clinic only) | 8am - 5pm                                  | CLOSED    | 9am - 5pm    |
| BORVE    | 9am - 5pm          | 9am - 5pm                      | CLOSED                                     | 8am-5pm   | 8am-5pm      |
| PAIRC    | CLOSED             | 10am - 1pm                     | 10am – 1pm<br>(meds<br>collection<br>only) | CLOSED    | 9.30am - 4pm |
| UIG      | 9.20am -<br>1.30pm | CLOSED                         | 10:30am - 5pm                              | CLOSED    | 9.30am - 3pm |
| BERNERA  | 2.30pm - 5pm       | CLOSED                         | 10am – 3pm                                 | CLOSED    | 8am – 1pm    |

### Protected Learning Time

Closed for staff training: the Practice will be closed for staff training every second Wednesday of the month, (eg. Wednesday 9th June, Wednesday 14th July, etc) from 1 – 6pm except for urgent calls. If you have an emergency please call the usual number **01851 860 222**.

### Triage process – new phone options from 14 June 2021

In order to improve the service to patients the practice are making a slight change to the way they triage patients looking for GP/NP appointments. From Monday 14th June when you phone the Practice you will be given these options:

Option 1 will be a dedicated line for appointments, so if you press 1 you will be transferred directly to the triage team.

Option 2 will be for anything else, so you press 2 for repeat prescription requests, changing appointment dates and general enquiries etc.

Our phone number remains the same: **01851 860222**.

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## WOMEN'S HEALTH

Cervical screening (also known as the smear test) saves around 5,000 lives every year in the UK and prevents eight out of 10 cervical cancers from developing. Six women are diagnosed with cervical cancer every week in Scotland, so it's really important to attend your cervical screening appointment when invited.

The NHS Cervical Screening Programme invites all women from the age of 25 to 64 to attend cervical screening. Women who are 25 to 49 years of age are offered screening every three years, and those aged 50 to 64 are offered screening every five years.

However, if you notice any of the following make an appointment with your GP as soon as possible:

- Abnormal bleeding: during or after sexual intercourse, or between periods
- Post-menopausal bleeding, if you are not on HRT or have stopped it for six weeks
- Unusual and/or unpleasant vaginal discharge
- Discomfort or pain during sex
- Lower back pain.

## IN MEMORIAM



Our much-loved father, Dr John Hay, died in the early hours of Sunday 9th May, peacefully at home, surrounded by family.

Following in his father's footsteps, Dad chose to study medicine. While at university he met our mother, Fay Macleod from Garenin, and they were married in 1957. After attending Bible College, they moved to central Thailand, where Dad worked in surgery at a Christian hospital. Two of my sisters were born abroad, while Kirsty and I were born in Carloway during our parents' time on furlough, before returning for a second stint in Thailand.

Returning to Scotland in 1970, Dad worked in Dundee for a couple of years, before accepting the post of GP for Uig and Bernera. It was a challenging post, requiring being on permanent call and covering a wide geographical area. But he loved getting to know all his patients, their homes and the details of their lives. Even on the roads, patients weren't safe, with crofters being flagged down and blood tests being carried out

in passing places! In return, Dad was often stopped by folk saying, "A wee present for the doctor," while passing suspiciously salmon-shaped packages through the car window.

Meg Buchanan, who took over from his long-suffering receptionist Murdina, in Miavaig surgery recounts, "When I worked in the surgery with him, every day was an adventure. Hardly a week went by when he didn't leave something major behind when roaring off to Bernera and he'd maybe have driven miles, remember, then roar back to get it! Or someone would have to take off to meet him."

When our mother died in 1999, Dad was left to soldier on alone, joining my family for his meal and various games every evening. What a privilege for my children, sharing so much of their lives with him- even if they had to hear the same stories and jokes time and time again. He had a special place in his heart for children, and loved spending time with them. Grandson Seumas could always distract him with the words, "Grandpa, can you help me with....?" Whatever Dad was doing at the time would immediately be forgotten as the two of them went off to complete some project together.

At the age of 73, Dad chose to walk the length of Scotland on his own, some 530 miles from the borders to Cape Wrath over a five week period. He spent his last night of the trek alone, in a remote bothy north of Kinlochbervie, before walking the final 8 miles across boggy moorland to the Cape Wrath lighthouse, turning round and retracing his footsteps 8 miles back to the bothy.

Always adventurous, he then accompanied Murray on a working cruise ship, visiting the Falklands and Antarctica in 2009. An avid photographer, he returned with thousands of pictures of penguins! He had also spent time getting to know the mainly Philippino crew, delighting them by learning some phrases in their native tongue.

At an early age, Dad committed his life to Jesus and his faith was central to everything he did. Many patients will remember the "wee word" at the end of a home visit, bringing spiritual as well as physical comfort. Rev Iain Murdo Macdonald recounts after his father's heart attack, "One of the enduring images my mother recalled from that time was Dr Hay on his knees by my father's bed, in earnest prayer for him." An elder in the Miavaig Church of Scotland, Dad often preached both in Uig and Bernera and always commented on the warm welcome he received from the Bernera folk.

Due to Covid restrictions, only close family and friends were able to attend the funeral, but the extended family are profoundly grateful for the messages of support and the lovely cards and tributes received since his death. His was indeed a life lived to its fullest and his passing leaves an immense gap in our lives and our community.

Dad's birthday was 23rd October and he often quoted Job 23 verse 10 as a verse of special significance to him:

"But he knows the way that I take; when he has tested me, I will come forth as gold."

**Janet Macleod**  
Uig





## BERNERA SCHOOL

It really does feel like the end of an era as Bernera School closes this month for the foreseeable future, due to lack of student numbers. The school has been such an integral part of the community for so long, and such an important part of so many people's lives. We asked some former pupils to share their memories of being at the school:

Skiddle-addle-off - this was a game that you tried to balance on the foundation wall of the school. If you met someone coming towards you and you were first to shout skiddle-addle-off, they would have to jump off. (mostly played by girls)

Favourite foods - School chicken curry, caramel tart, steak pie. All foods really. Great food!

The teacher parking their car in the playground and being scared you would hit it with the ball.

When it snowed, there would be a slide down the length of the playground until the cleaner fell and broke her leg on it and we were forbidden from then on.

Mince pies at Christmas.

Santa leaving a bag of apples for us to find when we went back after the Christmas holidays.

Our thoughts and thanks go to the dedicated staff, the children and the community for keeping it going all these years. We wish the remaining pupils all the best in their new schools and hope that you have a fabulous school holiday.

We would very much like to continue collating these memories and sharing them with you all, so if you have a memory or a story to tell about your time at the school please don't hesitate to get in touch. We'd also like to share any old photos that you may have. Anything that we do receive will also be shared with the Bernera Museum.



Picture by Sandiephotos

**L-R** - Ava Douglas (P7), Joseph Smith-MacInnes (P7), Donald MacLennan (P6), Rebecca MacKenzie (P4), Roseanne Smith-MacInnes (P7). **Front** - Carrie Douglas (P4).

## GENERAL KNOWLEDGE QUIZ ANSWERS FROM ISSUE 15

- |                       |                         |
|-----------------------|-------------------------|
| 1. Arctic Fox         | 16. Cod Wars            |
| 2. Aurora Australis   | 17. John F Kennedy      |
| 3. Iceland            | 18. Paddington          |
| 4. Mid Atlantic Ridge | 19. Zanzibar            |
| 5. Russia             | 20. Granny Smith        |
| 6. 21st December      | 21. Lizard King         |
| 7. Valhalla           | 22. AD69                |
| 8. Eider Down         | 23. Homer               |
| 9. The Jacobite       | 24. Damascus            |
| 10. Olympic           | 25. Judi Dench          |
| 11. Fair Isle         | 26. Prince Charles      |
| 12. Caledonian Canal  | 27. Sheffield           |
| 13. Mars Bar          | 28. HMS Queen Elizabeth |
| 14. Earth             | 29. Mods and Rockers    |
| 15. Loki              | 30. Eagle               |

**Colin Halliday**  
Kirkibost



## POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - THE GREENFINGERED CRAFTER

When we first talked about moving up here, I vividly remember telling "him indoors" that on no account did I want to end up a farmer's wife - kudos to anyone who does that kind of thing, it's incredibly hard work, but it's just not something I ever wanted.

So how do I find myself now, four years later, almost unable to remember a time I left the



house in footwear other than wellies, and catching myself muttering excitedly when I'm digging in a nice patch of good dirt and turning over a forkful to find a couple of worms??

Honestly, I have no idea. But the land just seems to kind of seep into your bones and without realising it you're not just looking out and feeling a sense of peace and good fortune at simply living here, you're thinking about ways to give something back to the land itself.

Which is kind of where we are now. This is our first full year of taking 'planting stuff' vaguely

seriously. I'm sure we're making all manner of classic rookie errors - our carrots aren't spaced out properly; the winter spuds were left in too long and turned into mush; we grew possibly enough cabbage to supply most of Lewis (we got carried away planting seeds and ended up with more seedlings than we had space to plant out) but we're learning! It seems ground coffee is deterring the slugs on the runner beans, and potatoes will grow in the scruffiest of soil.

We've spent time weeding a pile of turf cuttings and surrounding them in weed matting so hopefully recent plantings will have a better survival rate (although our carrots are still a bit too cosy!), and I have some ladybirds on the way - can't believe you can just order them from ebay! Plus we're not just focussing on planting for sustenance - we've planted a good mix of trees and hedging



just for variety and windbreak, plus lots of comfrey around the place, which I'm assured will do good things for the soil and is a massive hit with the bees.

We've also almost cleared the moss which was taking over our 'lawn', thanks to sowing a fabulous clover mix. We're also doing the whole repurpose thing with a salvaged fish farm pipe, turning it into a reusable tomato growbag.

We still have a very long way to go and so much to learn, but I'm kind of getting into it. Our days are planned around what the plants need, what the weather is doing, and how likely it is we'd get eaten alive by midges if we went outside.

Despite the neverending daylight hours, there's never enough time to get it all done, and apparently we're now thinking about chickens and a couple of pigs! I still maintain I don't want to be a farmer's wife, but maybe being a part time greenfingered crafter wouldn't be so bad?

**Claire Ritchie**  
Kirkibost



## MINI BEACH CLEAN

With an increase in noticeable plastic pollution on our shorelines across the UK, the charity **Surfers Against Sewage** is encouraging people to carry out mini beach cleans in an attempt to tackle the problem and raise awareness of the issue. They believe that, as long as you are respectful and stay safe, and only remove plastic pollution, you shouldn't have to ask permission or fill out loads of forms to remove some litter from your favourite places.

So, if you have a bit of spare time next time you're visiting the shoreline, why not get to work and take part in a mini beach clean. Make sure you get rid of the waste collected appropriately, recycling the plastic where possible. And why not share your hard work on social media using the hashtag **#MiniBeachClean**.

We at the Bernera News would also like to hear about any mini beach cleans that you do. Please feel free to send us photos via whatsapp to **07958 549784** or perhaps you could write us a postcard piece for us to include in a future issue, email **hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk** to share your words and thoughts.

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## WATER SAFETY

The Royal Life Saving Society's Drowning Prevention Week is being held from 19 - 26 June this year. The campaign aims to share invaluable advice and tips on how to stay safe near water.

### Tips include:

While at the beach, never let your young children out of your reach – supervision is the key to preventing serious accidents.

Always ask for local advice, for example from lifeguards, tourist information offices, local coastguard stations, or even local fishermen, on where and when it is not safe to stroll on the beach or enter the water.

Do not swim near or dive from rocks, piers, breakwater and coral.

Water safety signage can be very different in different countries, so find out what local warning flags and signs mean – and adhere to them.

Inflatable dinghies or lilos are a well-known hazard – there have been drownings as people on inflatables are blown out to sea and get into trouble. Do not use them in open water. Use them in sheltered and confined spaces, such as rock pools.

If you get stuck in quicksand or mud do not stand up. Lie down, spread your weight, shout for help and move slowly in a breaststroke action towards the shore.

If you witness an emergency, whether it is in the UK or overseas, know how to call for help.

### Rip Currents

Definition – Rip currents are currents of water typically flowing from the shoreline back out to sea. They are commonly formed by a build-up of water on the beach caused by wave and tidal motion but can also form where an estuary runs into the sea.

### How to Escape

Call for help

If you have a buoyant aid (like a surfboard or inflatable), keep hold of it

Do not swim against the current

Swim parallel to the shore – this makes sure that you are swimming out of and not back into the rip current

Once out of the rip current, swim towards the shore, being careful to avoid being drawn back in by feeder currents

Around 190 people lose their lives at the UK and Irish coasts each year, and over half never even planned to enter the water. If you find yourself unexpectedly in the water, float to increase your chances of survival. If you see someone else in trouble in the water, call **999** or **112** and ask for the Coastguard.



## PEASAN

Cha robh búthan anns a' bhaile far an do dh' fhás mi suas ach oifis a' phuist. An áite tháinig am béicear, an grósair, am buidsear agus an ceannaiche éisg len bhanaichean gach seachdain. Stad an grósair aig an taigh againn a h-uile Diluain ach nam biodach feum agad air rudeigin eile bha cothram ann sin fhaighinn DiMart, oir chaidh a' bhana seachad faisg air láimh.

Aon latha nuair a bha mise san sgoil, choisich mo mháthair cómhla ri mo bhráthair beag síos an rathad airson barrachd bídh a cheannach. Bha tíde gu leór ann fhathast mus tigeadh a' bhana, mar sin fhuair iad cuireadh bho nábaidh airson balgam.

'S e boireannach snog a bh' innte agus bha í glé dhéidheil air cait. Tha mi a' smaoinichadh gun robh trí neo ceithir dhiubh aice. Nuair a chaidh iad a-steach dhan seómar - suidhe, chunnaic iad cat na chadal ri taobh an teine.

Mus do shuidh iad síos aig a' bhórd thuirt am boireannach ri mo bhráthair: "Seall a Harailt, 's e sin Peasan".



Cha do thuig e dé bha i a' ciallachadh idir idir agus sheall e oirre le imcheist is fhreagar e: "Cha do rinn mi cáil sam bith. Chan e peasan a th' annam ach balach modhail!"

An uair sin thuirt ise: "Tha fios agam gu bheil thu modhail a' ghráidh. Bha mi a' bruidhinn mun chat. 'S e Peasan an t-ainm a th' airsan".

Nuair a chuala mo bhráthair sin, thoisich e air gáireachdainn agus bha a h-uile rud ceart gu leór a-rithist.

**Linne Macleod**  
Dun Innes



## BERNERA BAKES... SULTANA FLAPJACKS

Preparation time: 15 minutes - Cooking time: 25 to 30 minutes - Makes 12 flapjacks

### Ingredients:

115g butter chopped, plus extra for greasing  
3 tablespoons golden syrup  
85g caster sugar  
250g porridge oats  
55g sultanas  
Finely grated zest of one large lemon  
1 teaspoon vanilla extract

### Method:

1. Preheat the oven to 180°, grease a 18 x 18 x 5cm baking tin.

2. In a saucepan, gently heat the butter, syrup and sugar for five minutes until the butter melts and the sugar dissolves.

3. Remove from heat and stir in the porridge oats, sultanas, lemon zest and vanilla extract. Scrape the oat mixture into the tin and spread it out with the back of a spoon.

4. Bake for 20 to 25 minutes until golden brown, remove the flapjack from the oven and leave to cool in the tin, then cut into 12 slices



**Careen MacLennan**  
Kirkibost



## A DRAW'S A DRAW FOR A THAT

Even for those of us who have not watched football for a long time, especially those of us who were not au fait with the current crop of top-flight defenders, midfielders and forwards, Friday 18th June 2021 will last long in our memories.

This was the night when the mighty nation of Scotland was represented in the lion's den of Wembley by 11 young warriors. For many of us defeat was the expected outcome. The usual heroic performance always ending with Scotland losing in the dying seconds of the game. Just enough faith to keep us injected with hope up until the end of a game and then ka-bosch, a foul, a penalty or a free kick being the precursor to the Hampden groan! Oh no, not again!

This time things were different. Players passed accurately, confidently and intelligently to one another. Even moves that contained 5 to 10 passes without the other team robbing them of the ball. Possession, they say, is 9/10ths of the Law, and possession we had.

As the game went on the more amazed and overjoyed we became. Never was a draw so eagerly awaited and appreciated. At last, the final whistle blew. The cries went up, "We drew! We drew! We drew!"

It must have been the most celebrated draw since Michaelangelo painted the Sistine Chapel in Rome.

The future seemed so bright. The long-awaited prophetic fulfilment of Ally's Army was about to be realised against Croatia. Then Covid 19 robbed us of our star man. Then we went one - nothing down. Yet by half time it was one - one. Extinguished hopes were resurrected only to be cruelly crushed by another Croatian goal, and then another.

90 minutes gone and 4 minutes of extra time to play.....Come away ye blues!

Then the final whistle blew. We had lost.

If only Covid had not hit... if only we had used different tactics... So many 'if's' but there were no doubt's - Scotland had lost! Another Scottish campaign drew to a close and once again a prophetic promise was given "And we'll (i.e. the Scottish team) make sure it's not 23 years before we go to the next tournament." said Steve Clark.

Patience is a necessary characteristic of being a Scotland fan whether we like it or not.

True, Christian patience is also a virtue, as Paul tells us:

*"The Lord is good to those whose hope is in him, to the one who seeks him; it is good to wait quietly for the salvation of the Lord."* **Romans 8:26**

Thankfully, such a hope does not depend upon a future win but on a past victory by grace, through faith in our Lord Jesus Christ on the Cross.

**Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart**  
Uig & Bernera



## BERNERA BUY, SELL, SWAP



About a carrier bag full of Harris tweed samples from Sticky's Mill. Great for crafting projects. Free. If you're feeling creative, phone Susan on **07497 008644**.

Sam Millns has some spare Sweet Pepper and Chilli plants looking for a new home. If you'd like some please get in touch on **619375** or **07958 549784**

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